

Postmodernism

Brazen, varied, vibrant, and playful, postmodernism emerged in the late 1960s as a direct reaction to the restraint and discernment of modernism and functionalism. The movement evolved simultaneously in the arts, philosophy and architecture: in the latter its presence was felt through the increased use of decoration, idiosyncratic and humorous design and blocks of colour in preference to the relatively austere modernist materials of steel, glass and reinforced concrete.

The movement began in North America, instigated by Robert Venturi, who asserted that architecture should be more complex and cryptic. Others associated with postmodernism include Philip Johnson, Michael Graves, James Stirling and Frank Gehry. As well as abandoning modernist austerity, postmodern architects have often used modern materials and techniques to subvert expectations – for example adding incongruous and non-functional traditional features to modern buildings or creating what seem to be unstable structures.



National-Nederlanden Building in Prague, Gehry, 1992–6